

SLUMDOG'S CHILD STARS

Dream Catchers

Hair neatly tied in two pony-tails, shoes polished and her blue and white school uniform in place, Rubina Ali could be your neighbourhood school-going eight-year-old. Except that she's not. For one, Ali lives along the railway tracks in a teeming Bandra slum called Garib Nagar. More importantly, the tiny Preity Zinta fanatic essayed the role of the youngest Latika in *Slumdog Millionaire*. Clutching her father Rafique Qureshi's hand, Ali tries very hard to pronounce the English title of the film correctly, but when he sees her daughter struggle, Qureshi says, "She used to go to a municipal school but she's been going to an English-medium school since June last year." The admission and monthly fee of Rs 1,500 is being taken care of by the producers of the film. Ali earned Rs 35,000 that has since been spent on treating her father's fractured leg. Her father, who works as a carpenter, has already received a film offer for her but surprisingly he isn't interested. "I want her to complete her education."

It's an aspiration shared by Azharuddin Mohammed Ismail's family. Ismail, who plays the youngest Salim, lives with his parents and siblings in a makeshift plastic tent, pitched on a half-finished government park also in Bandra. His father is fuming over a local newspaper's false report that he asked the producers to give him cash instead of a ticket to Los Angeles for the Oscars. "My son is getting international recognition. Why would I say no to this," he screams. The son is unaffected. "My favourite scene is the one where Jamal and I are on top of the train and I lower him down," says the child

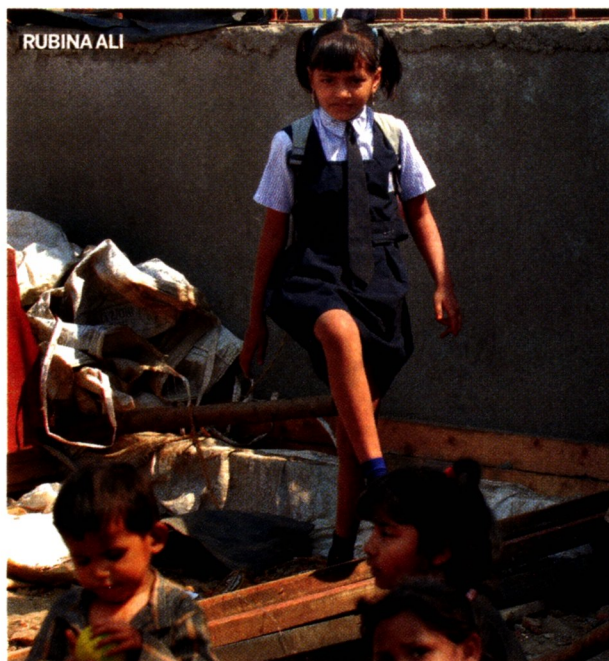
actor who was paid Rs 1.25 lakh for his role and is happy to be attending an English-medium school. That money unfortunately was spent on his ailing father's tuberculosis treatment. But despite the utter poverty, he remains hopeful, just as a 10-year-old would. "I will finish my studies and become an actor like Salman Khan."

In the distant Mumbai suburb of Bhayander (East), Ayush Mahesh Khedekar is a hero. "After *Slumdog Millionaire* was released and people saw my picture in the paper, they started treating me like a star," says the impish Khedekar. Facing the camera isn't new for the floppy-haired Khedekar. He's been acting in advertisements since he was four. His father, Mahesh Khedekar, who dabbles in Marathi theatre, says he got his portfolio shot and he soon got a role in the film *Family*. Constant media attention aside, there is something else keeping the child actor on his toes—preparing for his Los Angeles visit to attend the Oscars. Though for the world the red carpet at Kodak theatre might be 'the' event, Ayush is just excited that he'll get to meet the cast and crew again. "Danny uncle is my favourite," says Ayush, who recently appeared in commercials for Brooke Bond and HDFC Bank. If his dimpled face was a ticket to auditions, today coordinators and directors are calling his father on their own. Mahesh says, "But I'm not saying yes yet. I want the Oscars to get over first." Ayush, who one would think, aims to be an actor, is still deciding between being an actor and a scientist. Thankfully he still has time.

by Jhilmil Motihar



MANDAR DEODHAR



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SHRIYA PATIL SHINDE